in this district of ancient Arakanese monuments and the historic capital of the Arakanese kingdom. The Mahamuni Pagoda, which was considered central in Rakhine ethnic history, was located in Kyauktaw township. The Rakhine people experience Rakhine ethnic nationalism, centred on the historical glory of independent Arakan, in this district in a physically real sense. With this strength of ethnic nationalism, Rakhine ethnic parties have always done well in these townships. The scale of the ANP landslide win here was based firmly on ethnic appeals and communal antagonism, with Muslim people excluded from voting.

Kyaukpyu District also demonstrated the role Buddhist nationalism played in the 2015 elections in Rakhine State. Being at the epicentre of the 2012 communal conflict, the Buddhist Rakhine constituency would not view the NLD favourably. At the same time, people from Kyaukpyu District were given policy alternatives between the ANP, which promised a new conception of governance and development policy, and the USDP, which had not achieved any substantial improvements in these people's lives over the previous five years. Centred on the Shwe Gas project and Kyaukpyu Special Economic Zone activities, the ANP's ethno-nationalist argument of direct benefits for the local people from these mega-projects resonated strongly.

However, ethnic nationalism and Buddhist nationalism failed to get traction in Thandwe District and Munaung township. Historically, Rakhine ethnic nationalism has not been significant in these townships. In the 2010 election, the RNDP did not field any candidates in these constituencies, and in 1990, the NLD won all of these seats. As both Thandwe and Toungup were sites of communal conflict, Buddhist nationalist concerns would have been significant in these constituencies. However, the Buddhist-nationalist agenda against the NLD did not have as strong an impact as in the seats of Meiktila township in Mandalay Region, which went against the NLD and to the USDP (Maung Zaw 2015). In Thandwe District, the NLD's call for political change won out over the Buddhist nationalist calls against Daw Aung San Suu Kyi and the ANP's ethno-nationalist claim on Rakhine ethnicity.

In these townships, three-cornered contests between the ANP, USDP, and NLD occurred as all of them gained more than twenty but less than forty-four per cent, except in Gwa township. While a majority of the people in these townships would be identified as Rakhine, their ethnicity had not automatically translated to ethnic-nationalist aspirations and votes for the ANP. Although there are possibilities that local and personal issues disadvantaged the ANP, such as its choice of candidates or disorganized